

How to use Verbatim

Verbatim · version-scoped Q&A over psychological test-manual PDFs

App: <https://chiragsingla25.github.io/verbatim/> — user guide

Verbatim answers questions about a psychological test manual using **only that one manual version**, and shows you the page it came from. If the manual doesn't say, it tells you “not found in this version” — it never guesses and never uses the open web.

1. Create an account and sign in

- 1 Open <https://chiragsingla25.github.io/verbatim/>.
- 2 Choose **Create account**. Everyone starts as a **student** — read and ask.
- 3 Open the confirmation link Verbatim emails you (check spam if it doesn't arrive in a minute).
- 4 Come back and **Sign in**.

What each role can do

Role	Can do
Student	Pick a manual version, ask questions, read answers with citations, see their own history. This is every new account.
Contributor	Everything a student can, plus upload new manuals and review / publish them. An admin grants this.
Admin	Everything, plus the Admin console: manage roles, archive / re-publish / supersede manuals, read the activity log.

If **Upload manual** or **Admin** shows “Not available”, your account doesn't have that role yet — ask an administrator.

2. Ask a question

Step 1 — Pick a manual version. The **Manual library** is the default screen. Each row is one version of one instrument (edition and year matter). Click **Ask** →.

Step 2 — You are locked to that version. The header shows **ANSWERING FROM** with the manual name. Every answer in this session comes only from that version — there is no cross-edition blending, by design.

Step 3 — Type your question in the box at the bottom and send it. You'll see “Reading the manual...” while it works (usually 5–15 seconds).

Step 4 — Read the answer. A grounded answer has:

- a short answer paragraph, then a **verbatim quote** from the manual;
- **citation chips** like **[1] p.20** — click one to open the **source page** beside the answer, with the quoted passage highlighted;
- a **“Verified against source”** line — the answer passed a second automatic check that every claim traces to a retrieved passage from this version.

Step 5 — “Not found in this version.” This means the manual genuinely doesn’t contain the answer. It is a deliberate, correct response — not an error. Verbatim would rather say nothing than guess.

Superseded editions. If a newer version of the same manual has been published, a **“Superseded by ... →”** link appears in the header. The current version still works; the link just points you to the newer one.

3. Write good questions

Verbatim is at its best with **specific, factual questions the manual actually answers**:

- cut-off / threshold scores and severity bands (“What PHQ-9 score indicates moderately severe depression?”);
- norm-table values — means, SDs, percentiles for a stated group;
- administration and scoring rules, time to administer;
- reliability / validity figures (Cronbach’s alpha, sensitivity, specificity).

Tips:

- **Name the term the way the manual does.** “hazardous drinking cut-off”, not “the risky number”.
- **One question at a time.** Ask a follow-up as its own question.
- **Pick the right edition first.** A value from the 1st edition won’t be found if you’re asking the 2nd.

It deliberately **won’t**: give clinical or treatment advice, interpret a particular client’s scores, compare two manuals or editions, or answer anything not written in the version you chose.

4. My answers (history)

My answers in the sidebar lists every question you’ve asked, newest first.

- **Filter by manual** with the dropdown; **Load more** pages back through older questions.
- **Click a row** to reopen the exact answer as it was first given — same wording, same citations, no new lookup.
- **“Re-ask this against the current version →”** runs the question again from scratch against the same manual version. It appears only when that version still exists and is active.
- Your history is **private to you**. No one else — not even an admin — sees it on this screen.

5. For contributors — adding a manual

- 1 + **Upload manual** from the library.
- 2 Enter the instrument name, the version's title / edition / year, the licence class, and tick the attestation that you have the right to store the file.
- 3 Upload the PDF. Parsing (text, tables, search index) usually takes **2–4 minutes**, but the first run after a quiet spell re-downloads the parser models and can take **10–15**. The review screen shows progress and a link to the running job.
- 4 The version sits at **pending** until a contributor or admin reviews the extracted tables against the source and **publishes** it. Full steps are in **approve-manual-guide.pdf**.

v1 corpus is **public-domain instruments only** (PHQ-9, GAD-7, PSS, AUDIT, IPIP scales, and the like). No commercial or restricted manuals.

6. For admins — the console

Open **Admin** in the sidebar (**/admin**). Three tabs:

- **Users** — everyone who has signed up, with a role dropdown per person (student / contributor / admin). A role change takes effect on that person's next page load. **You cannot change your own role** (self-lockout protection).
- **Manuals** — every version and its status. **Archive** takes an active version offline; **Re-publish** brings it back. The **Supersedes** dropdown links an older version of the same instrument to this one.
- **Activity** — a read-only feed of role changes, publishes, rejections, archives, and supersede links, newest first, with who did each.

Archiving a version removes it from students immediately — it drops out of the library, can't be asked against, and its source PDF stops being downloadable. Students' existing **history** entries for it still render. Archiving is fully reversible with **Re-publish**.

7. Limits and safety

- Answers are **decision support, not clinical judgement**. Always verify against the source before clinical use — every answer links the page so you can.
- Each answer is **scoped to one version**. Editions are never blended.
- v1 has **no score calculators, no edition comparison, and no open-web knowledge** — those are out of scope on purpose.
- A slow answer or an over-cautious “not found” is acceptable; a wrong number is not. If an answer looks wrong, open the cited page and check.

8. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause / fix
"Not available" on Upload manual or Admin	Your account doesn't have that role. Ask an administrator to promote it.
Answer says "not found" but you're sure it's in the manual	Check you picked the right edition ; phrase the term as the manual does; it may be in a table that didn't extract cleanly — tell an admin so it can be re-reviewed.
The source page won't render ("Couldn't render the source page")	Usually a very old browser. Update to a current Chrome / Firefox / Safari and hard-refresh.
No confirmation email after Create account	Check spam. If it's still missing after a few minutes, try Create account again with the same address.
A manual you used has disappeared	It was probably archived or superseded . Your My answers history still shows the answers you already got from it.
You're asked to sign in again mid-session	Your session expired. Sign in again; your history is unaffected.

Pilot deployment — public-domain instruments only. Questions and manual requests go to the project owner.